

U.S. HISTORY HACK™

Teacher Graphic Organizer Toolkit

Unit 5 — The Great Depression & New Deal (1929–1941) • Reproducible

WHY THIS TOOLKIT

Knowing WHICH organizer to use, and WHEN, is half the battle. This toolkit tells you — with a brief why for each — then gives you reproducible blanks (Part 1) and per-standard Cornell support backs (Part 2). Tennessee connections are highlighted throughout; the local-to-national move is a HistoryHack signature and a point of difference for our classrooms.

Which Organizer, When — Quick Guide

Scan the left column for what the activity asks students to do; reach for the organizer on the right. Every organizer in Part 1 also carries its own “when to use · why it works” note.

When the task asks students to...	Reach for...	Why it works
compare / contrast TWO things	Venn (2) or T-Chart	Marzano's highest-yield strategy; the overlap names shared traits
compare 3+ things on set criteria	Compare & Contrast Matrix	systematic; lowers cognitive load
explain causes / effects	Cause & Effect	makes causal chains visible (SSP.05)
put events in order / show change	Timeline / Sequence	builds chronological reasoning (SSP.05)
brainstorm or connect ideas	Concept Web	activates prior knowledge; shows relationships
summarize a text or source	Main Idea & Details	separates the central idea from support
activate prior knowledge & track learning	KWL	metacognition; frames inquiry
learn a key term deeply	Frayer	deep vocabulary processing
analyze a primary source	HIPPO / OPTIC	disciplinary sourcing (SSP.01–02)
make and defend a claim	CER	claim + evidence + reasoning (SSP.04)
weigh two sides / a decision	T-Chart or Problem–Solution	structures evaluation
capture the basics of an event	5 Ws	ensures full coverage
connect a national event to Tennessee	★ Tennessee Connection	our signature local-to-national move

Reproducible — you may copy these pages for classroom use.

Part 1 — Reusable Blank Organizers (all subjects, all units)

Content-agnostic blanks. Print as many as you need; use across any standard or subject.

Task says “compare,” “contrast,” “how are they alike/different?” for TWO things. Marzano’s #1 strategy (identifying similarities & differences). The shared column forces students to name what overlaps, not just list traits.

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one

factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Venn (3) / Triple T-Chart — Compare THREE

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Comparing three people, groups, or ideas. Use the columns for each item and note shared traits in your notes.

Item A	Item B	Item C
Trait / criterion 1		
Trait / criterion 2		
Trait / criterion 3		
Trait / criterion 4		

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Two categories to sort or weigh: benefits vs costs, pros vs cons, before vs after, cause vs effect. Fast, low-floor entry point for comparison.

[illegible]

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Compare & Contrast Matrix — Items × Criteria

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Comparing several items across the SAME set of criteria. Reduces cognitive load by making the comparison systematic.

Criterion	Item 1	Item 2	Item 3

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Cause & Effect — Causal Chains

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Task asks “what caused...?”, “what were the effects/consequences of...?” Makes causal reasoning visible (builds SSP.05).

Cause	→	Effect
	→	
	→	
	→	
	→	

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Ordering events or tracing change over time. Builds chronological reasoning (SSP.05).

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Activating prior knowledge or showing how ideas relate to a central concept. Great as a pre-reading or review move.

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

5 Ws — Cover the Basics of an Event

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS	
Making sure students capture who/what/when/where/why of an event before analysis.	
Question	Answer
Who?	
What?	
When?	
Where?	
Why?	
MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS) Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first. Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?” Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “ _____ because _____, which shows _____.”	

Framer Model — Deep Vocabulary

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Learning a key term deeply (definition, characteristics, examples, non-examples).

Definition (own words)	Characteristics

Examples	Non-examples

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

CER — Build an Argument

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Any “make a claim / defend / argue” task. Claim + two pieces of evidence + reasoning (builds SSP.04).

Part	Write here
Claim	
Evidence (two specifics)	
Reasoning	

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

HIPPO — Analyze a Primary Source

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Analyzing a photo, cartoon, map, or document (builds SSP.01–SSP.02). Pair with OPTIC for visuals.

H-I-P-P-O	Prompt / notes
H — Historical context	
I — Intended audience	
P — Purpose	
P — Point of view	
O — Outside connection	

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

★ Tennessee Connection — Local ↔ National

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Whenever a standard has a Tennessee tie: link the national event to our state/community and say why the local story matters. This local-to-national move is a HistoryHack signature — use it often.

[illegible]

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Part 2 — Cornell Support Backs (per standard, reproducible)

Guided and Light scaffolds for each standard's Cornell notes — moved here from the student workbook so you copy them only as needed (MTSS). Fade Guided → Light → independent as evidence grows.

US.39 — Causes of the Great Depression: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
Great Depression	The worst economic downturn in American history, lasting from 1929 to the early 1940s, characterized by massive unemployment, bank failures, business closures, and widespread poverty.
Buying on Margin	The practice of purchasing stocks by borrowing money (paying only 10% down), which created a speculative bubble that burst when stock prices fell and investors couldn't repay loans.
Bank Failures	The collapse of thousands of banks during the Great Depression when depositors rushed to withdraw their money (bank runs), causing banks to fail because deposits weren't insured.

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of causes of the great depression was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of causes of the great depression was Great Depression: The worst economic downturn in American history, lasting from 1929 to the early 1940s, characterized by massive unemployment, bank failures, business closures, and widespread poverty.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Great Depression	_____ _____
Buying on Margin	_____ _____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Bank Failures	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Bank Failures and the Banking Crisis” section, and what evidence supports it?
- What is the main idea of the “Buying on Margin and Stock Market Crash” section, and what evidence supports it?
- What is the main idea of the “Overproduction and Credit Overextension” section, and what evidence supports it?
- Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.40 — The Dust Bowl: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
Dust Bowl	A severe drought and ecological disaster in the Great Plains during the 1930s, caused by drought and poor farming practices, creating massive dust storms that destroyed farms and forced migration.
Okies	Derogatory term for migrant farmers from Oklahoma, Texas, Arkansas, and Missouri who fled the Dust Bowl to seek work in California, often facing discrimination and poverty.
Black Blizzards	Massive dust storms turned day to night; buried farms; caused respiratory illnesses

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of the dust bowl was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of the dust bowl was Dust Bowl: A severe drought and ecological disaster in the Great Plains during the 1930s, caused by drought and poor farming practices, creating massive dust storms that destroyed farms and forced migration.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Dust Bowl	_____ _____
Okies	_____ _____
Black Blizzards	_____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Causes: Over-farming and Agricultural Practices” section, and what evidence supports it?
- What is the main idea of the “Causes: Severe Drought” section, and what evidence supports it?
- What is the main idea of the “Social Impacts: Migration and Displacement” section, and what evidence supports it?
- Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.41 — Impact of the Great Depression on the American People: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
Great Depression	The worst economic downturn in American history, lasting from 1929 to the early 1940s, characterized by massive unemployment, bank failures, business closures, and widespread poverty.
Hooverilles	Shantytown settlements of homeless people during the Depression, named mockingly after President Herbert Hoover, who was blamed for the economic crisis.
Mass Unemployment	During the Great Depression, unemployment reached 25% at its peak in 1933, with 15 million Americans out of work, creating widespread poverty and desperation.

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of impact of the great depression on the american people was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of impact of the great depression on the american people was Great Depression: The worst economic downturn in American history, lasting from 1929 to the early 1940s, characterized by massive unemployment, bank failures, business closures, and widespread poverty.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Great Depression	_____ _____
Hooverilles	_____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Mass Unemployment	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Mass Unemployment” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Effects on Families and Communities” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Internal Migration” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
-
-
-

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?

Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.42 — Herbert Hoover's Response: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
Herbert Hoover	The 31st U.S. President (1929-1933) who believed in limited government intervention and "rugged individualism," initially opposing direct federal relief for Depression victims.
Rugged Individualism	Hoover's philosophy that individuals should succeed through their own efforts without government handouts, emphasizing self-reliance and private charity over federal aid.
Bonus Army	Veterans who marched on Washington D.C. in 1932 demanding early payment of WWI bonuses. Hoover ordered the military to violently disperse them, damaging his reputation.

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of herbert hoover's response was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of herbert hoover's response was Herbert Hoover: The 31st U.S. President (1929-1933) who believed in limited government intervention and "rugged individualism," initially opposing direct federal relief for Depression victims.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — "This term means ..."
Herbert Hoover	_____ _____
Rugged Individualism	_____ _____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Bonus Army	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Philosophy of “Rugged Individualism”” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Public Works Projects” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Reconstruction Finance Corporation (RFC)” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
-
-
-

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.43 — FDR's New Deal Programs: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
New Deal	FDR's comprehensive programs to provide relief, recovery, and reform during the Great Depression, fundamentally expanding federal government power and establishing the social safety net.
Social Security Act (1935)	Landmark New Deal legislation creating a federal system of old-age pensions, unemployment insurance, and aid for disabled and dependent children, forming America's social safety net.
Tennessee Valley Authority (TVA)	Federal agency created to develop the Tennessee Valley region through hydroelectric dams, flood control, reforestation, and economic development, bringing electricity to rural areas.

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of fdr's new deal programs was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of fdr's new deal programs was New Deal: FDR's comprehensive programs to provide relief, recovery, and reform during the Great Depression, fundamentally expanding federal government power and establishing the social safety net.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____ _____
Explain	_____ _____ _____
Headline	_____ _____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — "This term means ..."
New Deal	_____ _____
Social Security Act (1935)	_____ _____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Tennessee Valley Authority (TVA)	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Relief Programs: CCC and WPA” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Recovery Programs: AAA and NRA” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Reform Programs: Banking and Securities” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
-
-
-

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.44 — Effects and Controversies of New Deal Policies: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
New Deal	FDR's comprehensive programs to provide relief, recovery, and reform during the Great Depression, fundamentally expanding federal government power and establishing the social safety net.
Socialism Charges	Conservatives: New Deal expanded government too much, threatened free enterprise and liberty
Court-Packing Plan	FDR tried to add 6 justices to Supreme Court (1937) after it struck down New Deal laws

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of effects and controversies of new deal policies was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of effects and controversies of new deal policies was New Deal: FDR's comprehensive programs to provide relief, recovery, and reform during the Great Depression, fundamentally expanding federal government power and establishing the social safety net.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — "This term means ..."
New Deal	_____ _____
Socialism Charges	_____ _____
Court-Packing Plan	_____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Economic Effects” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Long-term Structural Changes” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Charges of Socialism” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
-
-
-

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.